

Chapter 4: Architecture Definition

Overview

Chapter 4, "Architecture Definition" (pp. 53-62), tackles a deceptively simple question: what exactly *is* Enterprise Architecture? The chapter argues that clear, unambiguous definitions matter enormously, then shows that the TOGAF Standard itself does not offer just one definition of Enterprise Architecture — it uses three, drawn from different sources (ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022, Gartner via the Leader's Guide, and the BIZBOK Guide via FEAPO). Along the way, the chapter clears up the common confusion between Enterprise Architecture and IT Architecture, and closes by arguing that because no single, universally agreed definition exists, organizations must define for themselves how Enterprise Architecture is practiced internally so there is no ambiguity. This chapter belongs to the PINK and GREEN reading tours described in Chapter 1, Section 1.3.

Detailed Section Breakdown

Chapter Opener (p. 53)

The chapter opens with a note that it belongs to the PINK and GREEN reading tours (cross-referencing Figure 1-1 in Chapter 1, Section 1.3, for alternative reading paths through the book). The introductory text frames the whole chapter's thesis: definitions matter because they create clarity about what is being discussed. A precise definition leaves no room for interpretation, but when interpretation *is* left open, it leads to differing perceptions of the subject — with real consequences. The author states that in the field of Enterprise Architecture specifically, having an unambiguous definition is important, and previews that this chapter will present the many definitions of Enterprise Architecture that exist, while also pointing out that some essential parts are missing from the standard's own definition.

4.1 What Is Enterprise Architecture (pp. 54-56)

This section opens by noting that what exactly is meant by "architecture" (or "Enterprise Architecture") has been debated for years. It then presents the current TOGAF Standard definition directly:

> "The fundamental concepts or properties of an entity in its environment and governing principles for the realization and evolution of this entity and its related lifecycle processes." [7]

The text explains that with the publication of Technical Corrigendum 1 (2025), the TOGAF Standard now adopts the **ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022** standard as its basis for defining Enterprise Architecture. However, this definition alone still leaves room for interpretation, so the framework supplements it with additional text — effectively a second, complementary definition:

> "The structure of components, their interrelationships, and the principles and guidelines governing their design and evolution over time." [2]

Taken together, these two definitions indicate that architecture defines the *characteristics of a system*, and that the system is surrounded by frameworks overseeing its development. Crucially, the chapter stresses that in the TOGAF Standard, the word "system" is *not* restricted to an IT system — it can mean an organization (an enterprise), something even larger, or something smaller such as a project. This flexibility is presented as a deliberate source of interpretive latitude.

A sidebar box (p. 55) recalls that **Chris Greenslade**, Chairman of The Open Group in 2003, gave a presentation on TOGAF 7 (with a look ahead to TOGAF 8) that is described as progressive for its time (cross-referenced to Chapter 2, Section 2.2, for more background). His 2003 definition of architecture was:

> "Conceptually an (IT) Architecture is the fundamental organization of a system, embodied in its components, their relationships to each other and the environment, and the principles governing its design and evolution. Practically it is represented in Architectural Descriptions from the viewpoints of the Stakeholders." [8]

The section then makes its key critical point (p. 55): the current TOGAF Standard definition of Enterprise Architecture is missing an important component — **its relation to the achievement of business objectives**. The author argues Enterprise Architecture must ensure that business

objectives and their intended results are achieved, and must shape and organize itself to make this possible; it must ensure consistency and coherence between concepts, ranging from organizational structures to information systems, and from capabilities to applications.

A second sidebar (p. 56) offers the author's own working description of Enterprise Architecture: a framework for understanding and managing the overall structure and strategy of an organization; creating a holistic view of the organization's business processes, information systems, and technology infrastructure while maintaining coherence between them; aligning these elements with organizational goals and objectives so they work together effectively and efficiently; and identifying/resolving inconsistencies in business operations while enabling planning for future growth and development. The section closes by reiterating that definitions matter because they provide clarity and avoid confusion, and includes a Further Reading pointer to Chris Greenslade's original 2003 presentation (opengroup.org URL, p. 56).

4.2 Confusion Over Definitions (p. 57)

This short section addresses a persistent misconception: Enterprise Architecture is still frequently confused with **IT Architecture**. The chapter reminds the reader (cross-referencing Chapter 2, Section 2.2) that Enterprise Architecture has its historical origins in the technology corner, which is part of why the two are still lumped together. The author insists the two are "as different as night and day."

The distinction is drawn as follows: Enterprise Architecture is first and foremost about enabling an organization to achieve its goals and objectives and realize its strategy; it is used to address stakeholder concerns and answer questions about the organization's portfolio or specific projects. IT Architecture, by contrast, is far more technical in nature — "miles apart" from Enterprise Architecture. The author makes a strong claim: "There is absolutely nothing technical to Enterprise Architecture." Diagrams and matrices used in architecture efforts are often labeled "technical," but when used within an Enterprise Architecture practice they exist to answer stakeholder questions and address stakeholder concerns — they do not illustrate technical solutions.

A sidebar box (p. 57) reinforces that Enterprise Architecture oversees **all** the architecture domains (of which Technology Architecture is only one) and plays a coordinating role, leaving the execution of Technology Architecture to IT Architects. As such, Enterprise Architecture is positioned as a **strategic business management tool, not a technical instrument** [9]. The section closes by noting that the TOGAF Standard's definition of Enterprise Architecture is only one of many that

exist, and no single definition can be considered the ultimate one — which is presented as a lead-in to the next section.

4.3 Multiple Definitions (pp. 58-61)

This is the chapter's core section, systematically laying out the TOGAF Standard's three different definitions of Enterprise Architecture.

First definition recap (p. 58): the definition shown at the start of the chapter comes from the Core Concepts Guide of the TOGAF Standard and is based on the ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022 standard, maintained and updated by ISO.

Second definition (p. 58): Chapter 3 had described the TOGAF Standard's composition, including its Fundamental Content and additional Series Guides. One of these, the **Leader's Guide**, provides a second definition of Enterprise Architecture:

> "The process of translating business vision and strategy into effective enterprise change by creating, communicating, and improving the key principles and models that describe the enterprise's future state and enable its evolution." [3]

The chapter notes this definition originated with **Gartner** [10] and was created in **2008** — years before the 2022 ISO definition. The author flags a concern: using a definition drawn up in 2008 within a framework updated in 2025 "might raise a few eyebrows," since there is a real chance the definition is outdated and has since been superseded by Gartner itself.

Figure 4-1 (p. 59), "The many definitions of Enterprise Architecture," is introduced here to show the collection of all EA definitions used within (or referenced by) the TOGAF Standard. The figure is explained in detail: at the center sits Enterprise Architecture as the object being defined. Immediately surrounding it are five organizations that either provide their own definition or played a significant role in shaping the TOGAF Standard's adopted definition: **The Open Group, the Business Architecture Guild, the Federation of Enterprise Architecture Professional Organizations (FEAPO), Gartner, and ISO**. The diagram uses a color-coding scheme: blue ovals indicate the sources where individual definitions can be found (e.g., the TOGAF Standard's own definition is found in the tenth edition of the framework; Gartner's is published on its website);

yellow ovals indicate the specific references/citations where the definitions are articulated; and purple ovals indicate an actual definition of Enterprise Architecture, Business Architecture, or Architecture.

Third definition (p. 60): the BIZBOK Guide (a body of knowledge dealing with Business Architecture concepts in considerable depth) is referenced within the TOGAF Standard, and the TOGAF Standard makes use of its material. The BIZBOK Guide's own definition of Enterprise Architecture — itself based on the **Federation of Enterprise Architecture Professional Organizations (FEAPO)** — becomes, indirectly, a *third* definition present within the TOGAF Standard:

> "Enterprise Architecture represents the holistic planning, analysis, design, and implementation for the development and execution of strategy by applying principles and practices to guide organizations through the integration and interoperation of all other architecture domains."

The author highlights that this definition explicitly reflects the relationship to organizational strategy ("development and execution of strategy") and therefore to business goals and objectives — the very link the author earlier identified as missing from the TOGAF Standard's own primary definition (p. 60).

The apple/cherry/grape analogy (pp. 60-61): a sidebar illustrates why definitions matter using a simple example. Asked to describe an apple, most people will say something like "a round piece of fruit with a stem (and a small leaf) that contains vitamins," sometimes adding a color. But this description could just as easily describe a cherry or a grape. Granted, cherries and grapes are fruits too, but they are not apples — "To avoid comparing apples and oranges, definitions are used. They really matter" [9].

The section concludes (p. 61) that having multiple definitions of the same topic within a single standard is itself evidence of how difficult a topic Enterprise Architecture is to pin down; the discipline manifests differently at different levels, making a single conclusive definition elusive. The chapter's conclusion: there is no single, definitive definition of Enterprise Architecture, so it becomes particularly important for an organization to define how Enterprise Architecture is practiced internally, removing ambiguity. A Further Reading box (p. 61) points to an article on the variety of EA definitions at eawheel.com.

4.4 Summary (pp. 61-62)

The summary restates that Enterprise Architecture is a difficult topic to define, proven by the existence of multiple definitions for the same concept. It explicitly enumerates the **three definitions used within the TOGAF Standard**:

1. A definition based on the ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022 standard
2. A second definition from Gartner
3. A third definition, taken indirectly from the BIZBOK Guide

Each is then recapped in turn (p. 62):

- **First definition:** the TOGAF Standard adopts ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022 as its base definition, and adds a second clarifying text to make it more complete. The author reiterates the key criticism: a key component is missing from it — the realization of business goals.
- **Second definition:** described in the Leader's Guide, sourced from Gartner, who created it in 2008; adopted into the TOGAF Standard as updated in 2025 via Technical Corrigendum 1. The risk flagged again: an 8+ year old definition may now be outdated, and Gartner may have since revised it.
- **Third definition:** indirectly adopted from the BIZBOK Guide, which the TOGAF Standard references for the design and application of the Business Architecture domain — so BIZBOK's definition of Enterprise Architecture comes along with it.

The chapter's closing lines emphasize: "Three definitions in one standard." The profession of Enterprise Architecture is difficult to capture in a single definition; therefore it is more important for an organization to define how Enterprise Architecture is practiced internally, so there is no ambiguity within the organization (p. 62). This final sentence essentially restates the chapter's thesis and is the most quiz-likely closing takeaway.

Key Terms & Definitions

- **Enterprise Architecture (TOGAF/ISO definition)** (p. 54) — "The fundamental concepts or properties of an entity in its environment and governing principles for the realization and

evolution of this entity and its related lifecycle processes." Based on ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022, adopted via Technical Corrigendum 1 (2025).

- **Enterprise Architecture (supplementary/second half of TOGAF definition)** (p. 54) — "The structure of components, their interrelationships, and the principles and guidelines governing their design and evolution over time."
- **ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022** (p. 54) — The ISO standard the TOGAF Standard currently adopts (as of Technical Corrigendum 1, 2025) as the basis for defining Enterprise Architecture.
- **Technical Corrigendum 1 (2025)** (p. 54) — The 2025 amendment to the TOGAF Standard through which the ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022 definition was adopted.
- **Architecture (Chris Greenslade, 2003 definition)** (p. 55) — "Conceptually an (IT) Architecture is the fundamental organization of a system, embodied in its components, their relationships to each other and the environment, and the principles governing its design and evolution. Practically it is represented in Architectural Descriptions from the viewpoints of the Stakeholders."
- **IT Architecture** (p. 57) — The far more technical counterpart to Enterprise Architecture; concerned with technical solutions, executed by IT Architects, and coordinated (not performed) by Enterprise Architecture.
- **Leader's Guide definition of Enterprise Architecture (Gartner, 2008)** (p. 58) — "The process of translating business vision and strategy into effective enterprise change by creating, communicating, and improving the key principles and models that describe the enterprise's future state and enable its evolution."
- **Business Architecture Guild** (p. 59) — One of the organizations shown in Figure 4-1 that contributed to or provides its own definition related to Enterprise/Business Architecture.
- **Federation of Enterprise Architecture Professional Organizations (FEAPO)** (p. 59, definition detail p. 60) — Organization whose definition underlies the BIZBOK Guide's definition of Enterprise Architecture.
- **BIZBOK Guide** (p. 60) — A body of knowledge referenced by the TOGAF Standard, dealing in depth with Business Architecture concepts; source of the TOGAF Standard's third (indirect) definition of Enterprise Architecture.
- **BIZBOK/FEAPO definition of Enterprise Architecture** (p. 60) — "Enterprise Architecture represents the holistic planning, analysis, design, and implementation for the development and execution of strategy by applying principles and practices to guide organizations through the integration and interoperation of all other architecture domains."

Figures & Tables Referenced

- **Figure 4-1 — "The many definitions of Enterprise Architecture"** (p. 59): A diagram with Enterprise Architecture at its center, surrounded by five contributing organizations — The Open Group, the Business Architecture Guild, FEAPO, Gartner, and ISO. Blue ovals mark the source documents (e.g., TOGAF Standard 10th edition, Gartner's website); yellow ovals mark specific citations/references; purple ovals mark actual definitions (of Enterprise Architecture, Business Architecture, or Architecture). It matters because it visually consolidates why the TOGAF Standard ends up with multiple, sometimes conflicting, definitions of the same core concept.

Key Takeaways / Exam Focus Points

- The TOGAF Standard uses **three** distinct definitions of Enterprise Architecture within a single standard (p. 61-62): (1) ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022-based, (2) Gartner/Leader's Guide (2008), (3) BIZBOK Guide/FEAPO (indirect).
- The primary TOGAF definition is now based on **ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022**, adopted via **Technical Corrigendum 1 (2025)** (p. 54).
- The TOGAF Standard's core definition of EA is criticized as **missing the link to achieving business objectives/goals** (p. 55, repeated p. 62).
- The Gartner-sourced definition (via the Leader's Guide) dates to **2008** — a potential red flag for being outdated relative to the 2025-updated framework (p. 58, repeated p. 62).
- The BIZBOK/FEAPO definition is notable for explicitly including the link to **organizational strategy execution**, which the primary TOGAF definition lacks (p. 60).
- **Enterprise Architecture ≠ IT Architecture**: EA is strategic/business-focused (achieving goals, addressing stakeholder concerns); IT Architecture is technical. The author states EA has "absolutely nothing technical" about it — its diagrams/matrices answer stakeholder concerns, not illustrate technical solutions (p. 57).
- EA is described as a **strategic business management tool, not a technical instrument**, and it oversees all architecture domains (including Technology Architecture) in a coordinating role, while IT Architects execute Technology Architecture (p. 57).
- In the TOGAF Standard, the word "system" (as used in the definition of architecture) is **not limited to IT systems** — it can mean an organization/enterprise, something larger, or a project (p. 54).
- Figure 4-1's five contributing organizations to name: **The Open Group, Business Architecture Guild, FEAPO, Gartner, ISO** (p. 59).
- Chris Greenslade was **Chairman of The Open Group in 2003**; his TOGAF 7 presentation (with a look ahead to TOGAF 8) offered a 2003-era definition of (IT) Architecture (p. 55).

- The chapter's ultimate conclusion: there is **no single, definitive definition** of Enterprise Architecture, so organizations should define how EA is practiced internally to remove ambiguity (p. 60-62).
- The apple/cherry/grape analogy illustrates why vague descriptions fail and precise definitions matter — "To avoid comparing apples and oranges, definitions are used" (p. 60-61).

Self-Check Questions

Q: What standard does the TOGAF Standard currently adopt for its primary definition of Enterprise Architecture, and via which update?

A: ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022, adopted via Technical Corrigendum 1 (2025). (p. 54)

Q: What key component does the author say is missing from the TOGAF Standard's own definition of Enterprise Architecture?

A: Its relation to the achievement of business objectives (and their intended results). (p. 55, restated p. 62)

Q: In the TOGAF Standard's definition of architecture, what does the word "system" refer to besides an IT system?

A: It can refer to an organization (an enterprise), something even larger, or a project. (p. 54)

Q: Who gave a 2003 presentation on TOGAF 7 (with a look ahead to TOGAF 8), and what role did he hold at the time?

A: Chris Greenslade, who was Chairman of The Open Group in 2003. (p. 55)

Q: How does the chapter distinguish Enterprise Architecture from IT Architecture?

A: Enterprise Architecture is about enabling an organization to achieve its goals/objectives and realize its strategy, and about addressing stakeholder concerns; it has "absolutely nothing technical" about it. IT Architecture is far more technical in nature and deals with technical solutions. Enterprise Architecture oversees all architecture domains (including Technology

Architecture) and plays a coordinating role, while IT Architects execute Technology Architecture. (p. 57)

Q: What is the source and origin year of the TOGAF Standard's second definition of Enterprise Architecture (found in the Leader's Guide)?

A: It originates from Gartner and was created in 2008. (p. 58)

Q: What are the three definitions of Enterprise Architecture used within the TOGAF Standard, as enumerated in the Summary?

A: (1) A definition based on the ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022 standard; (2) a second definition from Gartner; (3) a third definition, taken indirectly from the BIZBOK Guide. (p. 61)

Q: Which body of knowledge is the source of the TOGAF Standard's third (indirect) definition of Enterprise Architecture, and whose definition does it itself rely on?

A: The BIZBOK Guide, which bases its definition on the Federation of Enterprise Architecture Professional Organizations (FEAPO). (p. 60)

Q: What five organizations surround Enterprise Architecture at the center of Figure 4-1?

A: The Open Group, the Business Architecture Guild, the Federation of Enterprise Architecture Professional Organizations (FEAPO), Gartner, and ISO. (p. 59)

Q: In Figure 4-1's color scheme, what do blue, yellow, and purple ovals each represent?

A: Blue = the specific sources where the individual definitions can be found (e.g., the TOGAF Standard's 10th edition, Gartner's website); yellow = the specific references/citations articulating the definitions; purple = an actual definition of Enterprise Architecture, Business Architecture, or Architecture. (p. 59)

Q: What does the BIZBOK/FEAPO definition of Enterprise Architecture include that the chapter says is notably good to see (and missing from TOGAF's own definition)?

A: Its explicit relationship to organizational strategy — "for the development and execution of strategy" — and thus to business goals and objectives. (p. 60)

Q: What is the chapter's overall conclusion about defining Enterprise Architecture, and what does it recommend organizations do instead?

A: There is no single, definitive definition of Enterprise Architecture; therefore organizations should define how Enterprise Architecture is practiced (or represented) within their own organization, so there is no ambiguity internally. (p. 60, restated p. 62)